

The Flavors of Asia and Australasia

Asia and Australasia contain virtually half the world's population and examples of most of the Earth's geography, so it's perhaps unsurprising that very few culinary opportunities are left unexplored among this melange of interconnected cultures and climates. Spices dominate the foods of Asia, but are used to flavor a huge range of cuisines with distinctive styles. Australasia has combined these with its European heritage to concoct a unique range of Pan-Asian dishes.

In the north of Asia, the arid Himalayan plateau descends to a vast swath of treeless steppes, where wheat is the staple and cooking is kept simple by the limited ingredients. Lower down, humid hills and river plains form the heartland of those two great Asian core crops – tea and rice – that pattern the upland slopes in terracing, color the landscape a rich green, and nourish half of humanity. Rice in particular holds the regional cuisines together, infinitely flexible in its uses: it's eaten steamed, fried, roasted, and boiled; made into

noodles, cakes, and wine; ground into flour and used in desserts. The rice belt extends south into the tropics, where heat, rain, and rich soils create an extraordinary fertility in which all manner of spices, fruits, and vegetables

flourish. Add to this the multitudes of farmed pigs and chickens and an abundance of marine life, and the menu becomes infinite.

A Rich Mixture of Cuisines

The story of Asian cuisine is one of cross-fertilization. In terms of variety and influence, India and China completely dominate the region. Migration, trade, and conquest spread the philosophies and cuisines of these two behemoths across Asia, though isolation and

distance have preserved local variations: a cuisine might be identifiably “Asian,” but there's a world of difference between a Cambodian *amok* fish curry and West Lake fish from China's Hangzhou. However, there are definite cooking “families”: Thailand, Malaysia, and Indonesia share a southern Indian love of spice pastes, coconut milk, and grilled foods; the cooking of Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam has clearer, cleaner flavors built around well-defined ingredients, perhaps closer to the studied simplicity and restrained palette of Japanese and Korean cuisine. India has no qualms about adapting foreign dishes – Mumbai's cosmopolitan *chaat* snacks, for example, embrace even Portuguese influences. Even that inward-looking cultural monolith, China, where alien ideas are absorbed so effectively that they eventually become Chinese, still shows evidence of contact with the outside world – in Peking duck, for instance, which probably owes a debt to Mongol cuisine.

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Right Federation Square in Melbourne, Australia, is a major meeting and eating point
Below Chefs preparing sushi in Tokyo, Japan – as much an art form as a dish

